GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT

Dastarkhan Disaster

A Kazakh Co-op Cooking Chaos Game

Genre	Players	Platform
Co-op Arcade	1–4 Co-op	PC (Steam)

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1. Elevator Pitch

Dastarkhan Disaster is a 1-4 player co-op cooking chaos game where players prepare traditional Kazakh dishes — beshbarmak, baursaki, kurt, and more — for increasingly demanding guests. Think Overcooked, but set in yurts, nomadic camps, and Nauryz celebration feasts. Every dish has a cultural soul, every failed order is a comedic catastrophe, and every successful feast earns the approval of the most demanding elder in the steppe.

The one-line hook:

"Overcooked set in a Kazakh feast — and grandma is watching."

What Is a Dastarkhan?

A dastarkhan is the traditional Kazakh feast cloth laid on the ground or table, covered with food and tea, representing hospitality, family, and celebration. It is the heart of Kazakh social culture — to be invited to someone's dastarkhan is an honor. Failing to fill it properly is a cultural disaster. This word is your game's entire emotional core in one noun.

2. Concept Overview

Core Fantasy

Players are frantically preparing a Kazakh family feast. Guests are arriving. The elder at the head of the dastarkhan expects perfection. Players scramble across the kitchen — chopping, boiling, frying, and assembling dishes — while the kitchen fights back with fires, broken equipment, wandering sheep, and limited counter space. When it works, it's beautiful. When it doesn't, it's the funniest thing you've ever filmed.

What Makes It Different from Overcooked

Feature	Dastarkhan Disaster vs. Overcooked
Cultural identity	Overcooked has no culture. Dastarkhan has KAZAKH culture baked into every mechanic.
Dish complexity	Kazakh dishes have a unique layered assembly — beshbarmak must be built in strict order.
Samovar system	Tea (chai) must always be available for guests. Running out is an automatic penalty.

Respect meter	Each guest has a Respect bar. Wrong dish = disrespect. Cultural stakes, not just a score.
Tandoor station	Shared clay oven with limited slots and no peeking — timed purely by ear and smell (visual cues).
Character roots	Playable characters are archetypes from Kazakh culture (grandma, shepherd, young bride, cook).
Level settings	Levels set in yurts, nomadic camps, Nauryz festivals, wedding tents — not generic kitchens.
Elder approval	A wise elder NPC observes and periodically issues demands that override your current plan.

Unique Mechanics Summary

The Samovar System

A large samovar (traditional brass tea urn) sits in the corner of every level. It must be kept filled with hot tea at all times. Guests expect tea immediately. If the samovar runs empty, all guest Respect meters begin dropping — it's a background crisis that creates a dedicated 'tea runner' role in larger teams.

Unity approach: Simple trigger zone + timer. Refill animation, particle steam effect. Acts as a persistent threat players must self-organize around.

Beshbarmak Assembly Line

Beshbarmak (the national dish) is the hardest dish in the game. It requires: (1) boil noodle dough sheets, (2) boil lamb separately, (3) combine on a large plate in layers, (4) pour onion gravy (tuzdyk) on top. Each step must happen in order. Skipping or wrong-ordering creates a 'wrong dish' that the guest rejects with visible disgust.

Unity approach: ScriptableObject recipe definition with ordered step validation. Each step = a trigger/ingredient state machine. Great foundation for all recipe types in the game.

Tandoor Blind Bake

The clay tandoor oven cooks baursaki (fried dough balls) and flatbreads. Players drop items in, but cannot see inside. Visual and audio cues (smoke color, sound pitch) tell players when items are ready. Leave them too long = burned. Pull them too early = raw. Creates tension through sensory discipline rather than a countdown timer.

Unity approach: Timer with randomized variance. Sound pitch lerps over cook time. Particle color shifts from white to grey to black smoke. Simple but highly memorable.

Respect Meter & Elder Demands

Each seat at the dastarkhan has a Respect meter. Wrong dish = -Respect. Correct dish served quickly = +Respect. If any guest's Respect hits zero, they leave and the round is failed. The

Elder NPC randomly issues priority demands mid-round ('Bring tea NOW', 'More kurt for the honored guest') that override the normal order queue.

Unity approach: Per-guest ScriptableObject state + event system. Elder demands are a randomized interrupt event. Simple but adds huge emergent pressure.

Kurt Drying Station

Kurt (dried salty cheese balls) must be shaped by hand (press minigame) and then placed on the drying rack for a real-time delay before serving. They cannot be rushed. This teaches players resource planning and pipeline thinking — you must start kurt long before it's needed.

Unity approach: Two-stage pickup interaction: shape (hold + release), place on rack, timer, then pickup. Teaches queue planning naturally.

3. Gameplay Loop

Session Structure

Phase	Description
Prep (0:00–0:20)	Read incoming guest orders. Stock stations. Start long-cook items (kurt, stews).
Rush (0:20–2:30)	Guests arrive. Orders pile up. Coordinate roles. Manage the samovar. Respond to Elder demands.
Crisis (2:30–3:30)	Kitchen events trigger (fire, broken station, wandering animal). Controlled chaos peaks.
Final Push (3:30–4:00)	Last orders come in. Score tallied. Grade awarded based on Respect and speed.

Controls (PC)

Input	Action
WASD / Arrow keys	Move character
E / Space	Pick up, interact, place item
Hold E	Chop, knead, shape (hold interactions)
Q / Shift+E	Throw item to teammate
Tab	View all current orders

Scoring System

At the end of each round, score is calculated from:

Factor	Effect on Score
Orders completed	+100 points each (base)
Speed bonus	+10 per second remaining when delivered
Respect rating	Multiplier: x0.5 (poor) to x2.0 (legendary)
Elder demands satisfied	+200 bonus each
Burned/wrong dishes	-50 per failed dish
Samovar empty time	-5 per second empty

Three stars require both high order completion AND high Respect. You can't brute-force speed at the cost of quality — cultural respect is mechanically mandatory.

4. Kazakh Dishes — Recipe Breakdown

Each dish is a real Kazakh recipe adapted into a cooking game step sequence. This is both a design choice and a cultural education feature.

Beshbarmak (National Dish — Hard)

Step	Action Required
1	Take dough sheet. Place on kneading board. Hold to knead.
2	Place kneaded dough in boiling pot. Wait for timer.
3	Place lamb cut into boiling pot (separate from dough). Wait for timer.
4	Pick up cooked dough sheet. Place on large serving plate.
5	Pick up cooked lamb. Place on top of dough.
6	Ladle tuzdyk (onion gravy) over assembled dish.
7	Carry to guest. Must match correct guest order.

Baursaki (Fried Dough — Medium)

Step	Action Required
1	Take dough ball from dough station.
2	Place in hot oil pan (or tandoor in later levels).
3	Wait for golden audio/visual cue. Pull out at right moment.
4	Place 3x baursaki on serving plate.
5	Deliver to guest.

Kurt (Dried Cheese — Easy Recipe, Time-Intensive)

Step	Action Required
1	Pick up kurt dough ball.
2	Hold interact button at shaping station to roll it.
3	Place on drying rack. Wait (long real-time timer).

4	Pick up dried kurt. Bag 3x together.
5	Deliver to guest.

Chai / Tea (Ongoing — Always Required)

Step	Action Required
1	Fill kettle from water source.
2	Place on samovar burner to heat.
3	Pour from kettle into teapot when hot.
4	Refill samovar from teapot. Samovar stays full.
CRISIS	If samovar empties: all guest Respect bars start dropping. Priority override.

5. Level Progression

Levels teach mechanics gradually, then combine them under increasing chaos. Each level is set in a culturally specific Kazakh environment.

Level	Setting & Key Mechanic Introduced
Level 1 — First Guest	Small yurt. 1-2 guests. Intro to pickup/deliver. Only baursaki and chai.
Level 2 — Family Arrives	Larger yurt. Introduce beshbarmak. Teach the samovar timer.
Level 3 — Nomadic Camp	Outdoor fire cooking. Introduce the tandoor station and blind bake mechanic.
Level 4 — Wedding Feast	Wedding tent. High guest count. Introduce Respect meter and Elder demands.
Level 5 — Nauryz Festival	Festival setting. All dishes unlocked. First appearance of kitchen events (fire, animal escape).
Level 6 — The Elder's Table	High-stakes dinner for an honored elder. All mechanics active. Perfection required for 3 stars.
Bonus — Blizzard Camp	Steppe blizzard level. Some stations freeze over and must be thawed. Chaos modifier layer.

Kitchen Events (Chaos Modifiers)

Random events trigger mid-level to disrupt players. These are the moments that create clips.

- A sheep wanders into the kitchen and bumps into carried dishes
- The tandoor fire flares up — nearby stations catch fire (extinguish mechanic)
- A pot boils over if left unattended too long — spills block floor tiles
- Samovar falls over — must be righted and refilled from scratch
- Elder arrives early and demands immediate tea service before any orders
- Storm wind blows open the yurt flap — food on unprotected stations blows away

6. Playable Characters

Four characters with unique passive abilities. Each is an archetype from Kazakh cultural life, not generic fantasy heroes.

Character	Passive Ability
Apa (Grandma)	Never burns baursaki — knows by instinct. Always cooks tandoor items to perfection.

Malika (Young Bride)	Carries two items at once (balancing a tray). Lower speed, higher carry capacity.
Jaksybek (Shepherd)	Can herd and move the kitchen animal event out of the way instantly.
Daniyar (Cook's Apprentice)	Chops and kneads 30% faster. Still learning the cultural nuances (lower Respect bonus).

Character selection adds replayability — the same level plays differently depending on team composition. Streamers love showing the 'wrong' character choice creating chaos.

7. Visual & Audio Direction

Visual Style

- Top-down 2.5D perspective (same as Overcooked) with a slight isometric tilt
- Art style: warm, hand-painted look with bold outlines — think Spiritfarer meets Overcooked
- Color palette: rich amber golds, deep reds, warm creams, steppe greens
- Kazakh geometric patterns (shanyrak, ornament borders) used in UI, level borders, and character clothing
- Every dish is a lovingly illustrated food sprite — food must look delicious, this is non-negotiable
- Yurt interiors: felt walls with woven patterns, wooden frames, low tables, cushions, soft light from the tundyk (roof opening)

Audio Direction

- Background music: live-recorded dombra (Kazakh lute) tracks, upbeat and rhythmic, tempo increases as pressure rises
- Sound effects: sizzling, steam, ceramic clinking, samovar bubbling, the crack of a burnt baursaki
- Guest voices: Kazakh language exclamations for happy delivery ('rahmet!'), disappointed delivery ('ai, bul ne?'), and Elder demands
- Kitchen event sounds: sheep baa, wind howl, fire crackle, water splash
- The Elder: deep, calm Kazakh voice. When he speaks, everything else goes quiet.

8. Business Model & Pricing

Decision	Choice & Reasoning
Price point	$9.99 — Below the no-hesitation threshold for a friend group buy

Release strategy	Early Access — 6 levels, 3 characters. Community feedback shapes full release.
DLC potential	Paid cosmetic DLC: character skins, regional kitchen themes (Russian Tatars, Kyrgyz, Uzbek kitchens)
Free updates	New dishes and levels added free — keeps community active and algorithms fed
Steam visibility	Niche cultural identity + co-op genre = strong discoverability in filtered Steam search

9. Viral & Marketing Strategy

Built-in Clip Moments

- The sheep event: teammate carrying beshbarmak gets bumped. Dish flies. Chaos ensues.
- Samovar crisis: one player desperately trying to refill while others ignore them.
- Wrong dish delivered: Elder slowly turns to face camera. Audio drops to silence. Respect bar empties.
- Two players try to pick up the same item simultaneously — one throws it accidentally into the fire.
- Four players all try to go through the same narrow yurt door with full hands.

The Cultural Angle is Free Press

There are zero other games set in a Kazakh kitchen. Journalists from gaming media, cultural media, and Kazakh national media will all have reasons to write about this. 'First Kazakh co-op cooking game' is a headline that writes itself. Pitch to:

- Gaming press: Kotaku, Rock Paper Shotgun, PC Gamer (co-op chaos angle)
- Kazakh & Central Asian media: cultural pride angle, national first
- TikTok: 30-second clips of chaos moments. Post weekly during development.
- Cooking TikTok crossover: recipe videos of the real dishes with a game overlay

Content Creator Strategy

- Target co-op content creators (200K–2M subscribers) who cover Overcooked, Moving Out, PlateUp
- Send early access keys 6 weeks before launch with a personal note and cultural context
- Host a 4-player streamer event (invite 4 streamers to play together) — clip highlight reel guaranteed
- Submit to Steam Next Fest with 2,000+ wishlists built first via devlog TikTok/Reddit

10. Scope & Unity Implementation

Why This is Beginner-Friendly in Unity

- Top-down 2.5D: no complex 3D navigation, no NavMesh for players, simple camera
- Interaction system: basic trigger zones + pickup/place scripts — well-documented for beginners
- Recipe system: ScriptableObjects per recipe define required steps — clean, extensible architecture
- No combat AI required — only physics events and timer systems
- Art asset scope: 2D sprites with simple animations. No character rigging needed.
- Netcode: Mirror or Fishnet for local co-op first, online later. Many Overcooked tutorials exist.

MVP Scope (3-Month Target)

System	MVP Version
Levels	2 playable levels (yurt, camp). Tutorial included.
Dishes	3 dishes: baursaki, chai, beshbarmak
Characters	2 characters: Apa, Daniyar
Mechanics	Pickup/place, recipe validation, samovar, basic Respect meter
Kitchen events	1 event: pot boil-over. No animal yet.
Multiplayer	Local co-op (same PC, split keyboard or 2 controllers)
Score	Star rating system, no leaderboards yet

Full Release Scope (12-Month Target)

System	Full Version
Levels	6 main levels + 2 bonus levels
Dishes	8 dishes (add kazy, sorpa, shelpek, shubat)
Characters	4 characters with unique abilities
Mechanics	All mechanics including Elder demands, tandoor, kurt drying, all kitchen events
Multiplayer	Local + online co-op (up to 4 players)
Score	Star rating, Steam leaderboards, daily challenge mode
Content	Kazakh language voice acting, animated cutscenes between levels

Development Milestones

Month	Milestone
Month 1	Core pickup/place/interact system. One prototype dish (baursaki) working.
Month 2	Recipe validation system (ScriptableObjects). Samovar mechanic. Prototype level.
Month 3	2 levels complete. 3 dishes. Local 2-player co-op. MVP build ready for feedback.
Month 4–6	4 levels. All 4 characters. Kitchen events. Polish pass.
Month 7–9	Online multiplayer. 2 more levels. Full Respect + Elder system.
Month 10–11	Audio, localization (Kazakh, Russian, English). Store page, trailer.
Month 12	Steam Early Access launch. Marketing push. Community feedback loop begins.

11. Competitive Landscape

Game	How Dastarkhan Disaster Differs
Overcooked 1 & 2	No cultural identity. No Respect system. No samovar. Generic kitchen settings.
PlateUp!	Single-player focused, deep management sim. Dastarkhan is pure co-op chaos.
Moving Out	Physics chaos but no cooking, no culture, no strategy layer.
Cooking Simulator	Realistic, solo, no chaos. Opposite end of the spectrum.
None	Zero games set in a Kazakh kitchen. This IS the category.

Bottom Line

Dastarkhan Disaster is the Kazakh Overcooked that doesn't exist yet. The genre is proven, the audience is established, the scope is beginner-friendly, and the cultural angle is a free differentiation tool that no competitor can copy. The clip potential is built into the design. The price point removes the buy hesitation. This is a game that markets itself.